3.1 What is a consumer?

Contract testing is built around the consumer and puts more control over their role than traditional integration testing. So, who is the consumer?

In day-to-day life, when you think about the consumer, what do you think about? Simply put, a *consumer* is a user of a product or a service. Think about all the products and services you use as a consumer, for example, the fridge and freezer that stores your food and the insurance policy you have to protect those products. Each person may use their products slightly differently or have different uses for their products. Fridges come in all different shapes and sizes, and many include freezer compartments. For example, one consumer may purchase a fridge to store their wine with a small freezer compartment for the ice. At the same time, another consumer buys a fridge freezer to store all their fresh ingredients and then needs the freezer to store the leftovers for reheating another time. The consumer is no different in software.

The consumer is usually a web or mobile app making requests to a backend service. However, a consumer can also be a service calling another backend service.

> **DEFINITION** In terms of software, a consumer is anything that makes a request for another service whether to retrieve data, post an update, or consume an event.

The consumer-driven approach contains the word consumer because the consumer is driving the contract. For example, the frontend web application controls the user experience in a web application requesting user login data. Therefore, the web application dictates what data it requires to surface this information to the user. Of course, the service returning the data can input the type and structure of the data. However, in the actual user experience, the user doesn’t care about how the data is structured. All they care about is being able to log in via the web application, which is why the consumer is so integral and should influence the expected data response. As shown in figure 3.1, the consumer request and expected response sets the data within the contract.